

to survive, they, unfortunately, cannot focus on the aspects that international agencies are looking at”. Further, she adds that MDI Gurgaon plans to go in for EQUIS Accreditation this year.

Attracting international candidates is a big road-block, admit the schools. Nagaraj even says it’s a dream we should give up on. “We should just recognise humbly that the type of student we want has many good choices. If faced with a choice between a top B-school in India and, say, a Carnegie Mellon, they would pick the latter.” Plus, Indian B-school placements are India-focussed, but an international student may not be interested in working in India, says IIMB’s Krishnan, but adds that IIMB is keen to bring in more foreign students through a scholarship programme, which its Board has recently approved.

Several schools are also facilitating international student and faculty exchange programmes to globalise the experience. For instance, Bhardwaj says MDI Gurgaon’s two-year MBA with International Business (IB) specialisation, where a student studies one year in India and the other in ESCP Business School in Paris, has had a lot of traction. “Almost all of the 120 students successfully completed their paid internships in Europe. Further, five-six of our faculty went on a one to two-week teaching assignment to European universities, and in exchange faculty from [some] European universities came to MDI Gurgaon to teach.” XLRI hosted 10 foreign students from three B-schools for one term of study in the academic year 2022-23. In exchange, they sent 29 XLRI students to nine business schools across five countries. “We are also focussing more on research professors and international visiting faculty,” says George.

India’s severe climes also play spoilsport, says IIML’s Jakhar: “We have collaborations with a lot of European B-schools. Except for the December-March term, the students find the weather too harsh to stay here.” Manish Gupta, Consulting Head at consulting firm MBA Crystal Ball, points out that India is not yet considered as a global management education hub. “Compare the number of Indians studying and settling abroad versus people from the US or UK wanting to do the same in India. Unless the perception shift happens, Indian B-schools cannot do much about the diversity quotient beyond a point.”

DIVERSITY ROADBLOCKS

Accreditation or not, the pedagogy of top Indian B-schools is no less, insist the colleges. But even they

Class Distinction

The average Indian MBA class is overwhelmingly made up of male engineers, at least among the Top 25 B-schools

Top B-schools	Male-to-female ratio*	Ratio of engineering to non-engineering students
	2022-23	2022-23
Top 1-25	2.0	61:39
Top 26-50	1.9	45:55
Top 51-75	1.2	24:76
Top 76-100	1.1	16:84

*Figures are the number of male students enrolled per female student, **Source** BT-MDRA survey



“Accreditation is not an affair to be taken lightly. It involves some investment of time, money, resources, etc.”

RISHIKESHA T. KRISHNAN
DIRECTOR,
IIM BANGALORE

admit that international schools take the cake when it comes to class diversity. “In B-schools, 50 per cent learning comes from professors and the rest from your batchmates. Culture and business are strongly correlated. When you have classmates from various cultures, you learn more,” says IIML’s Jakhar.

The average Indian MBA class is overwhelmingly Indian male engineer, shows BT-MDRA data, at least among the Top 25 B-schools in India. The numbers steadily improve in the colleges ranked lower in BT’s ranking. In fact, the ratio flips in favour of non-engineers and an almost 50-50 male-female gender ratio in the colleges ranked 76-100. It is perhaps an indication of quantitative bias in the CAT (Common Admis-